Ancient Greek Philosophy

Philosophy 201, Fall 1996 *Euthyphro* Outline

Introduction: 2a-5c

Setting: King-Archon's Court

Characters: Socrates, Euthyphro

- **(a) Socrates' Case 2b**
- **(b) Euthyphro's Case 3e**

Question: What is piety? 5d

Definition 1: Piety is doing what I am doing now, 5d

Objection: does not have proper form.

Socrates seeks

- **(a) some one thing 6d**
- **(b) a model 6e**

Definition 2: Piety is what is dear to (loved by) the gods. 7a

Elenchus (Refutation): The same things are both god-loved and god-hated. 8a

---

Definition 3: Piety is what all the gods love. 9e

Elenchus:

- **(a) Is it loved because it is pious?**

  or

- **(b) Is it pious because it is loved? 10a**

Socrates objects that Euthyphro's definition is of the form (b) not (a).

It describes an effect, or piety as having something happen accidentally to it.

Interlude: Socrates is like Daedalus, who made statues that ran away. 11c

Socrates' Hint: Piety is a part of justice. 12d

Definition 4: Piety is the part of justice concerned with care of the gods. 12e

Elenchus: How can we construe "care of" in this definition?

- **(a) "care of" = tending as in tending horses or sheep; aims at benefit. 13a**

  It is absurd to say that we are pious in order to benefit the gods.

- **(b) "care of" = service as in a slave's service toward a master. 13d**

  Service enables the thing served to achieve a fine end; but this is absurd to say about our service to the gods.

- **(c) "care of" = how to sacrifice and pray (= a kind of trading with the gods) 14c**

  This amounts to saying that if we are pious, we give the gods what pleases them. So we are back to Definition 2 or 3.

Conclusion: Socrates persists, Euthyphro runs off. 15d

---

return to:

Plato Outline

Ancient Philosophy Main Page

---

cfreeland@uh.edu